WORKFORCE DEVELOPMENT BOARD of Ventura County

CWA MEETING OF THE MINDS · MONTEREY 2026

Building Relevance

How Workforce Boards Become Indispensable Business Partners

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WHERE WE STARTED

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“The best kept secret in the county.”

That reputation was not a compliment. We were doing good work that employers could not see, name, or count on.

Invisible

Employers did not know we existed

Transactional

We showed up only when we needed something

Program-first

We led with our funding, not their needs

Where we are taking you

Our four-year journey, in six stops

01 **The Problem**
Employer vs. business thinking

02 **The Pivot**
A business-centered model

03 **The Build**
Team, sectors, outreach, guide

04 **The Tools**
Job quality, hiring, focus groups, AI

05 **The Results**
732 employers and a growth plan

06 **Your Turn**
Takeaways and a ready-to-use toolkit

LIVE POLL

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Let's start with you

In one word, how do businesses in your region describe your board?

Join at **slido.com**

Word cloud. We will read the room out loud in real time. Lets View the results here: *Let's view the results here!*

We were solving the wrong problem

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We treated businesses as employers to fill. They needed a partner who understood their business.

EMPLOYER LENS

- “Who can I place into your openings?”
- Outreach when we had a program to push
- Success measured by our enrollments
- One-size services, our menu
- Businesses were a means to our metrics

BUSINESS LENS

- “What is getting in the way of your growth?”
- Relationships built before we needed anything
- Success measured by their outcomes
- Tailored solutions around their priorities
- Businesses are the partner we serve

The pivot: a business-centered model

Four years ago we rebuilt business engagement on three commitments.

Trust first

We earn the right to help before we ask for anything in return.

Relevance always

We lead with the employer's priorities, not our funding streams.

Understand the business

We learn what actually drives their decisions, then design around it.

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03

The Build

Team, sectors, outreach, and the guide that ties it together

We built a team businesses want to talk to

Industry-focused subject matter experts aligned to the region's priority sectors, not generalists chasing every lead.

1

Sector expertise

Reps speak the language of the industries they serve, so employers feel understood from the first conversation.

2

Assigned relationships

Businesses have a consistent point of contact, not a rotating cast.

3

Solutions mindset

The team is trained to diagnose business needs, not just push openings into the system.

Aligned to where the region is growing

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We organize the team around Ventura County's priority sectors.

- Healthcare
- Advanced & Precision Manufacturing
- Agriculture
- Business & Professional Services
- Building Trades & Construction
- Technology & Innovation

We made ourselves easy to find and easy to use

Targeted outreach

Sector-specific campaigns that reach the right employers with a message that lands.

Business Solutions Guide

One clear menu of what we offer, in plain business language, ready to hand to any employer.

Systems that listen

We upgraded how we capture and respond to business needs so nothing falls through.

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Rate your own board

Where does your business engagement sit today?

1	2	3	4	5
Transactional	Responsive	Proactive	Business-centered	Indispensable

Slido rating poll · Code 6478613
Let's view the results!

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04

The Tools

Four practical tools you can adapt in your region

TOOL 01

The Job Quality Tool

WHAT IT IS

A simple diagnostic employers use to look at their own jobs: wages, benefits, scheduling, advancement, and culture.

We use it as a conversation starter, not a scorecard.

WHY IT WORKS FOR BUSINESS

It reframes us as a partner in better hiring, not a vendor filling seats.

Better jobs fill faster and stay filled, so quality is a business win, not a compliance ask.

TOOL 02 & 03

Hiring built around the employer

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WHAT IT IS

Customized hiring events designed around one employer's actual needs, timeline, and candidate profile.

Rapid reemployment hiring to fill urgent vacancies fast when a business cannot wait.

WHY IT WORKS FOR BUSINESS

Speed and fit are what employers value most. When we solve an urgent vacancy well once, we become the first call next time.

TOOL 04

Employer sector focus groups

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WHAT IT IS

Structured sessions where we bring employers in a sector together to tell us what they need.

The insight feeds directly into how we design and adjust services.

WHY IT WORKS FOR BUSINESS

Employers feel heard and shape the system they rely on.

We stop guessing and start designing services businesses actually asked for.

LIVE POLL

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Which could you build first?

Select all you could realistically adopt in the next 12 months.

- Sector-aligned team
- Business Solutions Guide
- Job Quality Tool
- Customized hiring events
- Sector focus groups

Slido multi-select · code 6478613

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05

The Results

What a business-centered model produced

From invisible to in-demand

PY 2025-2026 with a baseline from PY24-25, with a strategic plan to grow from here.

1132

employers served

Our established baseline and the number we are built to grow.

+54.6%

732 employers served in PY24-25

38

Hiring events which served 354 employers also the number of RR Events

WDBVC has greatly supported Community Memorial Hospital (CMH) by improving recruitment, increasing visibility, and connecting with Ventura County job seekers. Their outstanding service addresses workforce needs and raises awareness of CMH career opportunities.

What actually made the difference

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Lead with their problem

Every interaction starts with the employer's need, never our funding.

Put experts in the room

Sector fluency buys credibility that generalists cannot.

Let business shape services

Focus groups and feedback loops keep us relevant as needs shift.

Be patient, then consistent

Trust compounds. Show up before you need anything, every time.

Three things to take home

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01

A new model

Move beyond employer engagement to a business-centered partnership.

02

Real tools

Sector focus group guide and Job Quality Tool to understand needs and lift service delivery.

03

Ready templates

Business profiles, the Business Solutions Guide, and marketing materials you can use now.

Your take-home toolkit

Everything referenced today, ready to adapt in your region.

- Business-centered engagement model overview
- Sector focus group facilitation guide
- Job Quality Tool worksheet
- Business profile template
- Business Solutions Guide sample
- Marketing and outreach templates

Scan for the full toolkit

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FROM

~~the best kept secret~~

to the partner businesses call first.

Relevance is not a slogan. It is a system you can build.

SCAN ME

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Let's talk

Questions, challenges, and what you would build first.

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